ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Comparative clauses and scaling

Use elliptical comparative clauses, scalar correlatives and proportional expressions while controlling the comparison standard. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use comparative clauses and scaling to represent fine-grained differences and linked change without ambiguous or illogical comparison while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Use elliptical comparative clauses, scalar correlatives and proportional expressions while controlling the comparison standard.

MODEL

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

comparative + than/as-clause | the more X, the more Y

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main comparative clauses and scaling patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses represent fine-grained differences and linked change without ambiguous or illogical comparison.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in research, data commentary, criticism and sophisticated description.

Build meaning before form

Use elliptical comparative clauses, scalar correlatives and proportional expressions while controlling the comparison standard.

What comparative clauses and scaling communicates

Use elliptical comparative clauses, scalar correlatives and proportional expressions while controlling the comparison standard.

The central purpose is to represent fine-grained differences and linked change without ambiguous or illogical comparison. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.	a degree measured against a full predicted proposition
The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.	a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard
The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.	two degrees that vary together

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: comparative + than/as-clause | the more X, the more Y. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Clausal standard	comparative + than + finite clause	The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.
Elliptical comparison	as/than + reduced recoverable clause	The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.
Scalar correlation	the more/less X, the more/less Y	The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a degree measured against a full predicted proposition	Clausal standard
a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard	Elliptical comparison
two degrees that vary together	Scalar correlation

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in research, data commentary, criticism and sophisticated description. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01	02	03
comparative	than/as-clause	the more X, the more Y

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: represent fine-grained differences and linked change without ambiguous or illogical comparison.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits research, data commentary, criticism and sophisticated description.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Clausal standard	comparative + than + finite clause	The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.
Elliptical comparison	as/than + reduced recoverable clause	The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.
Scalar correlation	the more/less X, the more/less Y	The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.	a degree measured against a full predicted proposition
The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.	a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard
The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.	two degrees that vary together

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Ensure the compared dimensions are logically equivalent.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not omit material if the remaining phrase can attach in two ways.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use ordinary article meaning for the in this correlative pattern.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a degree measured against a full predicted proposition?

OPTIONS The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted. · The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones. · The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard?

OPTIONS The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones. · The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes. · The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: two degrees that vary together?

OPTIONS The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes. · The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted. · The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a degree measured against a full predicted proposition · a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard · two degrees that vary together

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard · two degrees that vary together · a degree measured against a full predicted proposition

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS two degrees that vary together · a degree measured against a full predicted proposition · a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Clausal standard / Elliptical comparison / Scalar correlation · Gap 2: a degree measured against a full predicted proposition / a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard / two degrees that vary together

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Elliptical comparison / Scalar correlation / Clausal standard · Gap 2: a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard / two degrees that vary together / a degree measured against a full predicted proposition

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Scalar correlation / Clausal standard / Elliptical comparison · Gap 2: two degrees that vary together / a degree measured against a full predicted proposition / a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

03 · PRACTICE STAGE

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a degree measured against a full predicted proposition: _____. Choose the model that expresses a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard: _____. Choose the model that expresses two degrees that vary together: _____. Choose the model built with comparative + than + finite clause: _____. Choose the model built with as/than + reduced recoverable clause: _____. Choose the model built with the more/less X, the more/less Y: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted. · The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones. · The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The effect was less pronounced _____. The intervention was more effective in rural areas _____. _____ the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes. State the full structural pattern for Clausal standard: _____. State the full structural pattern for Elliptical comparison: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The model predicted a stronger effect.” using the Clausal standard pattern to express a degree measured against a full predicted proposition.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “Effectiveness was higher in rural than urban areas.” using the Elliptical comparison pattern to express a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Precision reduces ambiguity proportionally.” using the Scalar correlation pattern to express two degrees that vary together.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The model predicted a stronger effect.” using the Clausal standard pattern to express a degree measured against a full predicted proposition.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Clausal standard to express a degree measured against a full predicted proposition, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Elliptical comparison to express a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Scalar correlation to express two degrees that vary together, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

Clausal standard is the best match because a degree measured against a full predicted proposition.

A2

The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.

Elliptical comparison is the best match because a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard.

A3

The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

Scalar correlation is the best match because two degrees that vary together.

A4

a degree measured against a full predicted proposition

The Clausal standard pattern communicates a degree measured against a full predicted proposition.

A5

a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard

The Elliptical comparison pattern communicates a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard.

A6

two degrees that vary together

The Scalar correlation pattern communicates two degrees that vary together.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Clausal standard / a degree measured against a full predicted proposition

The structure belongs to the Clausal standard pattern. Its communicative purpose is a degree measured against a full predicted proposition.

B2

Elliptical comparison / a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard

The structure belongs to the Elliptical comparison pattern. Its communicative purpose is a repeated predicate omitted from the comparison standard.

B3

Scalar correlation / two degrees that vary together

The structure belongs to the Scalar correlation pattern. Its communicative purpose is two degrees that vary together.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

Clausal standard: comparative + than + finite clause.

C2

The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.

Elliptical comparison: as/than + reduced recoverable clause.

C3

The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

Scalar correlation: the more/less X, the more/less Y.

C4

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

Clausal standard: comparative + than + finite clause.

C5

The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.

Elliptical comparison: as/than + reduced recoverable clause.

C6

The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

Scalar correlation: the more/less X, the more/less Y.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

than the preliminary model had predicted

Clausal standard requires “than the preliminary model had predicted” in this model. comparative + than + finite clause.

D2

than in urban ones

Elliptical comparison requires “than in urban ones” in this model. as/than + reduced recoverable clause.

D3

The more precisely

Scalar correlation requires “The more precisely” in this model. the more/less X, the more/less Y.

D4

comparative + than + finite clause

Clausal standard is built as comparative + than + finite clause.

D5

as/than + reduced recoverable clause

Elliptical comparison is built as as/than + reduced recoverable clause.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

comparative + than + finite clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended clausal standard effect.

E2

The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones.

as/than + reduced recoverable clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended elliptical comparison effect.

E3

The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes.

the more/less X, the more/less Y. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended scalar correlation effect.

E4

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted.

comparative + than + finite clause. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended clausal standard effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The effect was less pronounced than the preliminary model had predicted. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses comparative + than + finite clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

The intervention was more effective in rural areas than in urban ones. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses as/than + reduced recoverable clause accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The more precisely the question is framed, the less ambiguous the answer becomes. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses the more/less X, the more/less Y accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____